opposite side of the river, the Aūzbeg sulṭāns confronted him, presumably also expecting reinforcements. They initiated their move when they deemed themselves sufficiently strong to launch an attack, either by augmenting their own forces or upon learning that Babur had not significantly bolstered his own. It is possible to speculate that in the latter scenario, Babur had hoped for more substantial reinforcement than he actually received. He seems to have left Qūndūz before Mirzā Khān returned from his mission to Ismā‘īl, expecting Persian support to arrive with Mirzā Khān. At Pul-i-sangīn, where Mirzā Khān joined him in time for the battle, Babur likely drew strength from Mirzā Khān’s followers and a few, if any, foreign auxiliaries. These speculations find support in what Khwānd-amīr relates about the conditions under which the Shah’s primary contingent was dispatched, and he indicates that it did not depart until after the Shah had received news of the battle at Pul-i-sangīn.

At the end of the month-long waiting period, one morning, the Aūzbegs swam across the Sūrkh-āb below the bridge. In the afternoon of the same day, Babur withdrew to more favourable terrain within the mountain strongholds of a local Āb-dara. In the ensuing desperate confrontation, the Aūzbegs suffered a decisive defeat, incurring substantial casualties. They were pursued to Darband-i-ahanīn (Iron Gate) on the Ḥiṣār border, as they were en route to join a substantial force assembled at Qarshī under Kūchūm Khān, the successor to Shaybāni as Aūzbeg Khāqān. The battle is eloquently described by Ḥaidar, who was then a 12-year-old boy with a keen eye witnessing his own inaugural battle, fought against adversaries who had made him the last male survivor of his lineage. In the evening following the victory, Mahdī, Ḥamza, and Ḥamza’s son Mamak were presented before Babur. As recounted by Ḥaidar, Babur dealt with them in a manner akin to what they had previously done to the Moghūl Khāqāns and Chaghatāī Sulṭāns, exacting a measure of vengeance in blood for the lives of numerous kinsmen.

b) Persian reinforcement

After the battle, Babur relocated near Ḥiṣār, where he was joined by numerous local tribesmen. Some time later, a substantial force of troops from Ismā‘īl, led by Aḥmad Beg Ṣafawī, ‘Alī Khān Istiljū, and Shāhrukh SultanSulṭān Afshār, Ismā‘īl’s keeper of the seal, joined him. The details provided by Khwānd-amīr regarding the dispatch of this reinforcement help establish the sequence of events and shed light on the terms Babur had to meet for his auxiliaries. Babur reported his victory over Mahdī and Ḥamza to the Shah and simultaneously made promises. He pledged that if he, with the Shah’s assistance, reconquered the rest of Transoxiana, he would include the Shah’s name in the khuṭba,